Split decision

Chris Grace rarely refuses the offer of free wood, but then has to decide just what to do with it...

PHOTOGRAPHS BY JEAN GRACE

CHRIS GRACE

Chris has been turning wood since 2008. He has enjoyed making things with wood and metal on and off all his life alongside his work commitments, but the discovery of the lathe re-ignited his enthusiasm for working in wood. Chris sells his work by commission, demonstrates and provides instruction.

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As I help run South Downs Woodturners, I am often offered wood. Sometimes I pass it on to other members and other times it is obviously meant to be a personal challenge! This time it was clearly intended to be the latter: a freshly cut piece of holly (*Ilex* spp.), complete with its wrapper of ivy (*Hedera* spp.), presented to me by a fellow turner. What to make with it took a little pondering. I considered a traditional hollow form or an open natural-edged vase, however holly isn't that exciting as a wood, despite being a piece of crotch and there was clearly some evidence of grey in it. I wanted to use the features of the wood as much as practical, so I settled on a bowl shape, but I couldn't make a simple traditional shallow bowl as I would end up turning away too many features.

As it was given to me by another woodturner, I thought I would create something that might pose questions; such as how was it held, and where's the chucking point? Looking at the knot holes left by previously long-gone branchlets, I knew I wanted to retain them as a feature, but because of the shape of the wood, they would need to be on the bottom. I decided to pick the ivy off carefully in case I could make use of it later, and the more I looked at the naked wood, the more the idea developed.

I typically give my turnings quite a lot of thought before I start my lathe, to ensure that I can actually achieve what I have in my mind. Having said that, sometimes the ideas aren't fully formed; rather I let the creative process wander a little to allow the wood to influence the final result. Holding this piece was going to be tricky, but I thought I knew how I would be able to mount it safely, so it was off to the workshop to make some jigs.

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